

At Your SERVICE

They champion the cause of the underdog and fight to correct inequities. But NGOs have to grapple with inadequate funding and insufficient professionalism before they can become self-sustaining.

■ By A.K. Shiva Kumar

Vigorous voluntary public action reduces human suffering, corrects inequities, expands people's freedom and deepens democracy. These actions have acquired prominence in the era of globalisation and highlighted power asymmetries in decision-making within global organisations and forced a re-examination of the rules of conducting business by agencies like World Trade Organisation. It has drawn attention to issues such as human rights violations, gender injustice and environmental destruction, ignored by state and civil society.

Voluntary organisations have profoundly influenced policy, championed the cause of the underdog and worked towards assuring human rights, like SEWA in organising women workers, Naz Foundation in caring for children with AIDS and Dastkaar in empowering artisans. Equally powerful have been movements like Chipko, Narmada Bachao Andolan and the Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan as well as action research groups like the Centre for Science and Environment. They have also had an extraordinary influence in helping realise the right to food, education and information. A responsive judiciary, public interest litigation and establishment of institutions like the National Human Rights Commission have strengthened voluntary action in India. According to the Participatory Research in India (PRIA), a civil society organisation, there are over 1.2 million agencies in the non-profit sector, excluding self-help groups, cooperative societies, polit-

MANMOHAN SINGH, Congress member, 1999

"We are still a poor country but to soften the harsh edges of poverty we'll need social action."



FOR A CAUSE: Greenpeace activists demanding justice for Bhopal gas victims, in Delhi in 1998

ical parties and religious establishments. But over half are small, unregistered and three quarters have volunteers or at the most, a paid employee.

The significance of voluntary action will grow in the future. Voluntary actions promoting citizens' active participation will become critical. Increasing demands on an already over-stretched government will leave the state little option but to seek the voluntary organisations' cooperation.

There are enormous opportunities for the sector to make meaningful contributions with the government open to partner with NGOs. The private sector is also looking at becoming responsible corporate citizens. But is the voluntary sector ready to accept the challenges of a resurgent India? The answer isn't positive, with many NGOs demanding state accountability but lacking transparency. Many don't have the